

**Treated or Contaminated? How Media Systems Shaped Coverage of the Fukushima
Water Discharge in Japan, China and South Korea**

COMM2891 Asian Media and Communication

Assignment 1: Major Research Essay

Topic: Japan's Treated Fukushima Nuclear Wastewater Discharge

Student name: [Your full name]

RMIT student number: [s00000000]

Contact: [your student email] / [your phone number]

Tutorial class: [Tutorial class code, day and time]

Tutor: [Tutor's name]

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On 24 August 2023, the operator of the wrecked Fukushima Daiichi nuclear plant began releasing treated water into the Pacific, and within hours China banned all Japanese aquatic products (Hall & Zhang, 2023). The International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) had judged the plan consistent with international safety standards and its radiological impact negligible (International Atomic Energy Agency, 2023), yet even the water's name was contested. Japanese officials insisted on *treated water* (*shorisui*) and condemned *contaminated* as a gaffe ("Fisheries Minister Under Fire," 2023). China's Foreign Ministry spoke of *nuclear-contaminated water* (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China, 2023). South Korea's ruling party moved to rename the widely used *contaminated water* as *treated contaminated water* ("PPP Decides to Refer," 2023).

This essay compares coverage in Japan with coverage in China and South Korea, the neighbours that reacted most strongly and whose media systems contrast most sharply with Japan's, from Japan's April 2021 decision to the September 2024 China–Japan monitoring agreement. It argues that a national-interest frame dominated coverage in China and South Korea. In Japan, mainstream media largely carried the government's scientific-safety frame, and the national-interest frame was advanced mainly by affected domestic groups. Using the social amplification of risk framework, it explains this difference through state–media relations, political parallelism, geopolitics and platform governance. Evidence on emerging media is uneven, so claims about platforms are made cautiously.

Key Concepts and Evidence

Framing means to "select some aspects of a perceived reality and make them more salient in a communicating text" so as to promote a problem definition, causal interpretation, moral evaluation and remedy (Entman, 1993, p. 52). Frames are read here through the label

given to the water and the actor held responsible. A national-interest frame is coverage whose problem definition centres on the reporting nation's stakes (citizens' health, fisheries and trade, reputation or historical grievance) rather than on radiological evidence. A scientific-safety frame, by contrast, defines the problem by technical evidence and international standards.

The social amplification of risk framework explains why risks that experts judge minor can provoke strong public concern and substantial social and economic impacts. Risk signals pass through amplification stations, including scientists, news media, cultural groups and interpersonal networks, which can intensify or attenuate them (Kasperson et al., 1988). Domestication is the newsroom process of making foreign events meaningful by relating them to national concerns (Clausen, 2004).

Traditional media are professionally edited news organisations, including state media, whatever their delivery channel. Emerging media are platforms on which users, influencers or covert accounts circulate content ranked by algorithms or trending lists, and platform governance means the rules that decide what surfaces. Media systems are compared on the role of the state and political parallelism, the extent to which media mirror party divisions (Hallin & Mancini, 2004). China falls outside these Western models, closer to the Soviet communist theory of the press (Siebert et al., 1956). Japan's *kisha* (press) clubs tie reporters to officials and homogenise news, whereas South Korea's media environment is pluralistic and polarised (Arrington, 2017). English-language dailies such as the *Japan Times*, *China Daily* and *Korea Herald* (Gong et al., 2024) address foreign readers, so their framing counts only as outward self-presentation.

Japan: Scientific Safety in the Mainstream, National Stakes at the Margins

Japanese mainstream coverage largely carried the government's scientific-safety frame, which drew legitimacy from the IAEA's endorsement (C. Sun et al., 2026). The label

was policed: when Agriculture Minister Tetsuro Nomura called the water *contaminated*, echoing Beijing's term, he drew cross-party criticism and apologised ("Fisheries Minister Under Fire," 2023). Editorial positions differed mainly within that frame. A study of *Asahi Shimbun* editorials describes the conservative *Yomiuri* as treating the release as necessary and scientifically justified, and the *Mainichi* as more cautious, questioning whether government explanations were adequate (C. Sun et al., 2024). The mainstream debate thus turned on the adequacy of the science and of official explanation.

The national-interest frame came mainly from affected domestic groups. The fisheries federation, Zengyoren, kept its opposition, accepting that the water might be scientifically safe but fearing reputational damage (Reuters, 2023). Later, 151 fishers and residents, two-thirds of them from Fukushima, sued to halt the discharge (Associated Press, 2023). Some outlets gave these groups space. The *Tokyo Shimbun*, while still using *shorisui*, reported that the government was proceeding without keeping its 2015 promise that no disposal would occur without fishers' understanding ("Shorisui 24-Nichi," 2023). Their stakes, fisheries and reputation, stood in tension with the government's technical rationality (C. Sun et al., 2026).

This pattern fits Japan's media system. As the releasing state, Japan's government had an interest in defining the issue by evidence, and press clubs, which give member outlets privileged access to official sources (Arrington, 2017), carried that definition into the mainstream. Japanese watchdog journalism also tends to doubt rather than openly criticise (Lee et al., 2024). Abroad, the English-language *Japan Times* presented a unified image-protection discourse built on scientific evidence and counter-blaming (Gong et al., 2024).

Platform evidence is mixed. Around the 2021 decision, Japanese-language tweets concentrated on the water's long-term handling and, like tweets in other languages, were negative (Lyu & Lu, 2023). A study of Japanese YouTube discourse on nuclear energy found significantly negative sentiment towards government responses and the treated-water release

(Y. Sun et al., 2025). Yet Chinese state media and inauthentic accounts also targeted Japan with exaggerated risk narratives (Digital Forensic Research Lab, 2024), so part of the online negativity may have been amplified from outside. Japanese platforms therefore show that the official frame did not settle online debate, not that domestic users broadly rejected it.

China: One Frame, Amplified Online

Chinese coverage defined the release by national and moral stakes. On release day, the Foreign Ministry condemned Japan's unilateral discharge of *nuclear-contaminated water*, questioned its data and accused Tokyo of passing the risk to the world (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China, 2023). Chinese official and mainstream discourse from 2021 to 2024 advanced an Environmental Justice frame stressing historical accountability and ecological risk (C. Sun et al., 2026). Official outlets, including the English-language *China Daily*, cast the release as a war and the Japanese government and plant operator as liars (Li & Chen, 2024), so this evidence is partly outward-facing. Such homogeneity reflects the Soviet communist logic in which the press serves the party (Siebert et al., 1956).

On Weibo, platform ranking amplified rather than diversified this frame. A graphic from Yuyuan Tiantian, an account believed to be linked to state broadcaster CCTV, claimed that Japan had allocated 70 billion yen for public relations. Its hashtag drew 667 million views on the hot-search list (Freedom House, 2023). An article criticising anti-Japanese netizens' illogical arguments was quickly censored (Freedom House, 2023). Across 56,526 Weibo posts, technical discussion gave way to nationalist rhetoric led by grassroots users, in two strands: volatile anti-Japanese grievance and steadier anti-Western scepticism (Qin & Lee, 2026). Grassroots leadership within state-set limits is best read as participatory persuasion, in which netizens co-produce official messaging (Repnikova & Fang, 2018). In

the terms of the social amplification framework, state media and Weibo acted as amplification stations.

South Korea: Partisan Frames Around a Shared Anxiety

South Korean coverage also defined the release by national stakes, but divided over which ones. In 2021 the progressive Moon Jae-in government explored taking Japan to an international tribunal (Al Jazeera, 2021). The conservative Yoon Suk Yeol government later said it respected the IAEA's findings without supporting or opposing the release ("Yoon Faces Mounting Protests," 2023). Headlines in four major dailies from 2019 to 2024 show both camps initially using *concern* (Kim, 2026). After Yoon's inauguration, conservative papers switched to *disinformation*, pairing it with *mad cow disease* and *fake news*, while progressive papers treated that label as a ruling-party weapon (Kim, 2026). Progressive outlets stressed environmental and health risks and government accountability, conservative outlets diplomacy and governance (Chang, 2025). Polarisation peaked before the release and then eased, although strongly partisan outlets held their positions (Chang, 2025).

Politicians performed the rival frames. The Democratic Party's protests centred on the Yoon government's close alignment with Japan, and its leader Lee Jae-myung, on hunger strike, warned that the president risked complicity in what he called Japanese nuclear terrorism. Ruling-party lawmakers dined on seafood to show it was safe ("Fukushima Release Has South Korean Politicians," 2023). Anxiety was nonetheless widespread: 84% of South Koreans disapproved of the release in a joint Korean–Japanese newspaper poll, and sea-salt prices stood about 30% above a year earlier (Kuhn, 2023). This resembles the Polarized Pluralist model, in which outlets act as partisan interpreters (Hallin & Mancini, 2004), and matches the more openly critical Korean watchdog style (Lee et al., 2024).

Platform evidence is thinner. The government's YouTube video on the "truth" of the water drew more than 16 million views in under two months, a figure critics suspected had

been inflated (“Questions Mount,” 2023), and a China-linked network posted hundreds of Korean-language messages amplifying the protests (Microsoft Threat Analysis Center, 2024). Naver comment sections and partisan YouTube channels have not been studied on this issue in the sources reviewed, leaving Korean platform dynamics open.

Explaining Similarities and Disparities

Two similarities stand out. Labels carried frames in every country, as the policing of *contaminated* in Japan and the renaming contest in South Korea show. Public concern also exceeded the technical assessment: consumers bought salt in China and South Korea, and Japanese fishers feared reputational damage (Hall & Zhang, 2023; Kuhn, 2023; Reuters, 2023). This gap between a negligible technical risk and a large social response is what the social amplification framework predicts, with stigma and economic loss as its ripple effects (Kasperson et al., 1988). The handling of uncertainty and transparency shaped this amplification (Gong et al., 2024). The pattern is also consistent with domestication: Korean headline choices tied the release to domestic partisan conflict (Kim, 2026), and the *Tokyo Shimbun* centred the promise to Fukushima fishers (“Shorisui 24-Nichi,” 2023). These are editorial outputs, however, not direct evidence of newsroom processes.

The disparities follow from which amplification stations dominated. Japan’s mainstream media largely attenuated alarm by relaying official reassurance, whereas Chinese state media and Weibo amplified it, and South Korea’s press split between progressive amplifiers and conservative attenuators. State–media relations explain the first two cases: Japan’s government, as the releasing party, framed the issue by evidence and press-club access carried that frame (Arrington, 2017), while China’s party-state fixed both label and evaluation. Political parallelism explains South Korea (Kim, 2026). Geopolitics shaped the stakes. China’s frame drew on anti-Western scepticism and historical accountability (Qin & Lee, 2026; C. Sun et al., 2026), while Seoul’s opposition attacked the government’s

alignment with Tokyo (“Fukushima Release Has South Korean Politicians,” 2023). Platform governance, finally, channelled Weibo nationalism outward while dissent was censored (Freedom House, 2023), whereas Japanese YouTube commentary could target the government (Y. Sun et al., 2025).

Official frames proved durable. In September 2024 China agreed to resume imports gradually after additional monitoring (Al Jazeera, 2024). Beijing nonetheless restated its opposition and presented the deal as binding Japan to its international obligations, while Tokyo stressed its readiness for extra monitoring (Al Jazeera, 2024).

These findings complicate a simple contrast between Japanese science and Chinese propaganda. Japan’s scientific-safety frame also served national reputation abroad (Gong et al., 2024), and Chinese nationalism was led by grassroots users rather than simply imposed (Qin & Lee, 2026). Because the three models were built on Western democracies (Hallin & Mancini, 2004), they work better in East Asia as dimensions than as fixed categories.

Conclusion

A national-interest frame dominated coverage of the Fukushima discharge in China and South Korea, but not in Japan. There, mainstream media largely carried the government’s scientific-safety frame, and the national-interest frame was advanced mainly by fishers and plaintiffs, whose claims critical outlets reported. The social amplification of risk framework explains both the shared public concern and the differences: Japanese mainstream media mostly attenuated alarm, Chinese state media and Weibo amplified it, and South Korea’s partisan press did both. State–media relations, political parallelism, geopolitics and platform governance determined which stations dominated. Emerging media extended rather than displaced these patterns, although the uneven platform evidence, especially for South Korea, means this conclusion needs further testing.

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